

SPORT THINKS

By Ed Orman
Sports Editor

San Francisco's Giants are in a bad way for catchers. They have been on the prowl for reinforcements back of the log, but to no avail at this time.

Horace Stoneham, like other club owners, has negotiated for Ed Bailey of the Cincinnati Redlegs. Ed is the most sought after backstop in the National League, but Cincinnati is not letting him go without getting a front line pitcher or other talent.

The Giants list Valmy Thomas, who hit .249 in 129 games his first year with them last season; Nick Testa, up from Dallas where he hit .235; Bob Schmidt, up from Minneapolis where he batted .261; Ray Katt, a light tapper with New York for five seasons, and rookie Roger McCardell who batted .304 for Sioux City in 1957.

That is not an imposing cast.

Stoneham has dispatched Tom Sheehan, chief scout from the Giants training site in Phoenix, to Florida to try to land a catcher. Big Tom has a big job on his hands.

Seems to us the Giants could have looked into their own San Francisco peninsula back yard, and gone all out to attempt to lure Fresno Jack Shepard, now on the administrative staff of his alma mater, Stanford University, back into the National League.

Although he signed a 1957 contract with Pittsburgh, the club which signed him in 1953, Shepard quit to return to Stanford. Jack said he could see no great future in professional baseball for him so he put away his gear.

Bragan Tabbed Shepard 'Most Intelligent'

Branch Rickey had plans for Shepard when he signed him for a prominent role in the Pittsburgh youth movement. Shepard, a former Roosevelt High School (Fresno) athlete, was taken from the Stanford campus to the majors and caught two games with Pittsburgh. Then he was sent to Denver of the Class A Western League. In a month, he made the grade and in his first 30 games he hit .400. Manager Andy Cohen did not hesitate to put the "can't miss" tag on the Fresnan. He wound up hitting .324 and earned a chance with the Pirates in 1954. He made the grade and stuck three years. His average dropped from .304 in 1954 to .239 and then .242. He caught most of the Bucs' games each season.

Regardless, the Pirates counted on Shepard to be the No. 1 catcher in 1957.

Bobby Bragan, the vociferous exmanager of the Pirates, said "Shep was the most intelligent catcher I ever met." Bragan was a catcher most of his career.

"He didn't want to be associated with mediocrity," Bragan contends. "He would rather be a good professor than a mediocre catcher and you can bet he will be a good professor. In spite of his appraisal of himself, I think he did a pretty good job for us as a catcher, and he hit the long ball occasionally. But he saw a better future for himself as a college faculty member."

Maybe Shepard quit baseball too soon. There's a shortage of good catchers. Ask San Francisco and the Los Angeles Dodgers.



Jack Shepard — Brainiest of backstops.